

World Cup 2026 · Sweepstake

How the Projections work — the Monte Carlo model

The Projections tab estimates each player's chance of winning the prize money by simulating the rest of the tournament thousands of times — here is the model, step by step.

1. Team strength (Elo rating)

Every team gets an Elo rating. The starting rating comes from the bookmakers' outright “to win the tournament” odds — the shorter the price (the higher the win %), the stronger the team. That base is then nudged by real results: after each finished match the winner gains rating points and the loser loses them (a standard Elo update). Early on the odds dominate; as more games are played, results count for more.

2. Match model (Poisson goals)

For any fixture, the gap between the two Elo ratings is turned into an expected goal “supremacy” — how many more goals the stronger side should score. Each team's goals are then drawn from a Poisson distribution around its expected tally. That gives win / draw / loss probabilities and a most-likely scoreline.

3. One simulated tournament

The remaining group games are played out with the match model to complete the twelve group tables. The top two from each group, plus the eight best third-placed teams, qualify (32 teams). They are seeded by rating into a knockout bracket and played round by round to a champion and a runner-up; a knockout still level after normal time is settled by a rating-weighted shootout.

4. Thousands of runs (Monte Carlo)

Because every game is random, one run is just one possible tournament. So the whole thing is repeated about 3,000 times. Counting how often each team wins, or finishes runner-up, across all those runs gives its Champion % and Runner-up %. The “Re-run” button simply draws a fresh batch of simulations, so the numbers wobble slightly each time.

5. Projected returns

Each player owns six teams, so their expected return is:

$$\text{Expected £} = P(\text{a team of theirs wins}) \times \text{£80} + P(\text{a team is runner-up}) \times \text{£20}$$

Added up across the eight players this always comes to the £100 on offer for those two prizes.

Good to know

- It is a model, not a forecast — it shows the spread of likely outcomes, not what will actually happen.
- The bracket uses rating-based seeding (strong teams kept apart), a close stand-in for the real draw, which isn't set until the group stage ends.
- Everything is computed live in your browser from the latest odds and results — nothing is stored.